

Bayesian Optimisation of a Bio-Based Polyester Resin for Cured Thermoset Strength

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Abstract

This paper will focus on particular group of thermosets, namely, polyester resins. These liquid resins generally cured to form the matrix that surrounds reinforcing materials within the structure of composite materials such as glass-reinforced plastic. This paper initially elucidates the method by which an entirely bio-based polyester resin was manufactured, from simple organic acids and alcohols. Subsequently, a description of the method and associated results of Bayesian optimisation routines designed to improve the strengths exhibited by these materials will be brought to bear. The most salient findings include the mere possibility that these prepolymers can be manufactured simply and cheaply. Additionally, it is worth noting their strength being comparable after optimisation to their contemporary incumbents; the styrene-based unsaturated polyester resins.

1 Introduction

Plastics encompass a plethora of polymeric materials which provide a wide-range of desirable material properties; and given this, have seen use in a variety of applications, spanning both commodity and engineering settings [25]. Since the 1950s, the annual mass of plastics manufactured has grown from 2 Mt yr⁻¹ [24] to around 460 Mt yr⁻¹ in 2019 [18]; naturally, plastic waste tracked this rise. In 2019, 353 Mt of plastic waste was generated globally, with 49% landfilled, 22% mismanaged, 29% incinerated, and 9% recycled [18]. Mismanaged plastics may degrade and pollute watercourses with microplastics [27], incinerated plastics provide a means by which fossil carbon may reach the atmosphere [19], and sluggish development of recycling globally makes this the least likely fate of waste plastic [18]; these are a subset of the many challenges born out of the use of this family of materials.

Since around 85% of virgin plastic manufactured is thermoplastic they have generally dominated plastic sustainability literature, with papers focussed upon improvement of recycling methods [29], mitigation of mi-

croplastic waste [45], and biodegradability [44]. Despite their proportional minority, this paper focusses upon the group of plastics called thermosets- plastics characterised by cross-linked network structures, high dimensional stability, and chemical corrosion resistance [39]. It is generally impractical to depolymerise cross-linked thermoset materials which has lead to the common practice of either landfilling or incinerating these materials at end-of-life [66, 10, 64]. Contemporary European legislation has prioritised incineration ahead of landfill for composite materials with thermosetting matrices, and incoming legislation (e.g. Directives ‘99/31/EC’ and ‘2000/53/EC’) is likely to increase the proportion incinerated [51]. As the majority of thermoset plastics are derived from fossil sources of carbon, their combustion releases the greenhouse gas CO₂ into the atmosphere, perturbing the short-term carbon cycle [36]. This research directly treated this challenge through the application of Bayesian optimisation in the development of strength in bio-based alternatives to fossil incumbents.

Many thermosets exist including (but not limited to) phenolic resins, unsatu-

rated polyester resins, epoxy resins, and polyurethanes [26]. A prominent group are the unsaturated polyester resins, which are routinely used in the manufacture of composite components; these resins exhibit desirable properties including ease of handling in liquid form, rapid curing, and excellent dimensional stability [3, 33]. The simplest form of conventional unsaturated polyester resin would be that formed from the mixture of poly(propylene glycol fumarate) copolymer (polymerised from propylene glycol and maleic anhydride) with a styrene reactive diluent [1]. Unfortunately, all monomers associated with conventional unsaturated polyester resins are fossil-derived products: propylene glycol is industrially manufactured from propylene oxide- a downstream chemical product of propane extracted from natural gas [36]. Maleic anhydride is synthesised by catalytic oxidation of the chemical butane [22]- this derived from fractional distillation of petroleum crude [31]. And styrene is produced from the dehydrogenation of ethylbenzene- this being the product of a reaction between benzene and ethylene, both of which are fossil-fuel derived feedstocks [34, 36].

Recently, literature has explored development of bio-based synthesis of these monomers; it has been shown that propylene glycol can be synthesised from the biodiesel-manufacturing byproduct glycerol via hydrogenolysis [17, 52], or from the hydrogenation of the sugar-fermentation derived product lactic acid [6, 68]. Meanwhile, bio-based maleic anhydride can be synthesised from either oxidehydration of n-butanol (from biomass fermentation of C5 and C6 sugars) [50] or catalytic oxidation of furfural (from the dehydration of C6 sugars) [38, 63]. Even bio-based styrene has been successfully manufactured via a biosynthetic route from glucose [42].

This paper focusses upon bio-based unsaturated polyester resins based on itaconic acid, a simple bio-based difunctional carboxylic acid manufactured by fungal fer-

mentation of sugars by fungi such as *Aspergillus terreus* [4]. Itaconic acid's dicarboxyl and monoalkene functionality allows it to directly substitute maleic acid during polycondensation to form an unsaturated polyester [5]. Furthermore, itaconic acid can be synthesised into a variety of diesters (the family of diitaconates) which exhibit properties appropriate of a reactive diluent (i.e. radical initiated homopolymerisation and a low viscosity), allowing them to replace styrene in an eventual unsaturated polyester resin [58]. Bio-based itaconic acid has the advantage of being more directly synthesised from sugars than maleic acid, whilst diitaconates are a less volatile, less harmful and less flammable alternative reactive diluent to bio-based styrene.

Literature has explored catalytic influence upon polycondensation of itaconic acid within eventual unsaturated polyesters [55], synthesis of partially bio-based resins incorporating itaconic acid based unsaturated polyester but retaining styrene as the reactive diluent [13], as well as fully bio-based resins using itaconic acid based unsaturated polyester in tandem with diitaconates as reactive diluents [48, 47]. As an aside, literature has also considered partially bio-based resins incorporating itaconic acid based unsaturated polyesters together with the cross-linking compatible methacrylate class of reactive diluents [59, 16]. Although traditionally fossil-fuel derived, recent work has seen bio-based methyl methacrylate synthesised from itaconic acid, which would unlock fully bio-based resins based on methacrylate reactive diluents in future [46, 8]. Diitaconates were nonetheless focussed upon in this research (despite inferior homopolymerisation rates [58] and viscosity characteristics [59]) ahead of methacrylates on account of their relatively higher strengths as cured thermosets [59], safety as reactive diluents (lower toxicity and flammability) [35], and environmentally-benign nature as a non-volatile organic compound [59, 65].

On account of the temporal and finan-

cial expense of synthesising the chemicals concerned, the sample-efficient technique of Bayesian optimisation was used to facilitate the development of strength in these bio-based materials [23]. Literature describes how this technique has been used to successfully accelerate optimisation in a variety of domains: improving synthesis efficiency in organic chemistry [57], reducing phenotyping costs during crop breeding in plant science [62], and tuning microfluidic device setup for polymer fibre synthesis in materials science [37].

In polymer science, Bayesian optimisation has been deployed in both purely computational domains (e.g. optimisation of thermoplastic repeat units for improved glass transition temperatures in a simulated parameter space [43]) as well as in applied practice (e.g. improving compositional homogeneity during co-polymerisation of styrene and methyl methacrylate [61]). Various thermosets have been practically optimised using Bayesian optimisation: Benzoxazine-based thermosets have been optimised with respect to six thermomechanical properties [40], polycyanurates have had three thermal/mechanical/hygroscopic properties improved upon [69], and epoxy thermosets based on amine curing agents have been optimised with respect to a trio of mechanical properties using a dual-driver method [70]. In the more specific domain of practical Bayesian optimisation of bio-based thermosets, literature has been dominated by epoxy-based chemistries; Albuquerque et al. successfully improved glass transition temperatures in bio-based epoxy thermosets derived from amino acid based resin systems [2], whilst Rothenhäusler et al. explored this class of thermosets further by taking into account both cost and bio-based content [53]. Bayesian optimisation has seen practical application in the development of thermoset composites with a paper by Schoenholz et al. considering unidirectional carbon fibre prepreg based on epoxy resin; here, both the layup and curing cy-

cle variables were optimised to reduce the process-induced deformation in final composite parts [54]. Despite this, no literature exists concerning the practical application of Bayesian optimisation in the development of properties in polyester-based thermosets, their bio-based analogues, or their derived composites. In applying Bayesian optimisation for the development of strength in simple composites derived from itaconate-based thermoset chemistries, this paper addresses this gap in the literature.

2 Method

Optimisation experiments involved both the practical methods associated with preparation and characterisation of thermoset composite samples as well as computational techniques developed to carry out Bayesian optimisation based on data obtained. Furthermore, synthetic routines were developed for producing any materials not readily available commercially. Initially, this section will present practical methods including synthesis of itaconic acid polyester and diesters, thermoset composite preparation, and characterisation techniques employed. Subsequently, computational method by which Bayesian optimisation was implemented will be elucidated.

2.1 Materials

The propylene glycol (99%), itaconic acid (99%), anhydrous calcium sulphate (99%), and hydroquinone (99%) were supplied by “Thermo Scientific Chemicals”, a division of *Thermo Fisher Scientific Inc.* based in Waltham, Massachusetts, U.S. The toluene (99.8%), dried magnesium sulphate (99%), sodium chloride (99.5%), and dichloromethane (95%) were supplied by “Fisher Chemicals”, a division of *Thermo Fisher Scientific Inc.* The mixed xylenes (97%) were supplied by “Alfa Aesar” a division of *Thermo Fisher Scientific Inc.* The methanol (99.9%) was sup-

plied by “Honeywell Riedel-de Haën”, a brand under *Honeywell International Inc.* based in Charlotte, North Carolina, U.S. The p-toluenesulphonic acid monohydrate (98%) and chloroform-d (99.8%) were supplied by “Sigma-Aldrich”, a subsidiary of *Merck KGaA* based in Darmstadt, Germany. Dibenzoyl peroxide (20%) filled with calcium sulphate was supplied by *Nouryon Specialty Chemicals B.V.* based in Amsterdam, The Netherlands. Sodium bicarbonate (99%) was supplied by *Fluorochem Ltd* based in Glossop, Derbyshire, U.K.

2.2 Background

This research centred on the optimisation of a simple bio-based composite comprised of a thermosetting polymer matrix and a particulate reinforcing material.

Thermoset Polymer Matrix The thermosetting matrix was based on a cross-linked unsaturated polyester system; these rely upon a combination of condensation and addition polymer. The condensation polymer is typically an unsaturated linear polyester formed from the copolymerisation of diols and diacids, with at least one monomer having an unsaturated double bond in its structure which is retained after copolymerisation- this copolymer is referred to as an unsaturated polyester [56]. Whilst the addition polymer is typically generated through a radical-addition homopolymerisation reaction, where a monomer which had been acting as an unsaturated polyester solvent reacts and crosslinks individual unsaturated polyester chains- these monomers are therefore referred to as reactive diluents [11]. The combination of unsaturated polyester and reactive diluent is known as an unsaturated polyester resin; a viscous liquid, which, on addition of radical-initiating chemicals, can rapidly form a rigid thermoset material.

Previous work by Panic et al. found dimethyl itaconate to be the strongest contender of the diitaconates as a bio-

based replacement for styrene in unsaturated polyester resins, given that resultant cured thermosets exhibited relatively higher crosslink densities (73 % the density of a styrene-based thermoset) [47]. This work therefore sought to replicate these unsaturated polyester resins, where the reactive diluent was pure dimethyl itaconate and the unsaturated polyester was poly(propylene itaconate).

Particulate Reinforcing Previous work by Kharas et al. made use of particulate calcium sulphate in the preparation of bioresorbable bone cement composites, where it’s content was known to effect the final thermosets’ strength and modulus [30]. This work therefore employed the readily-available anhydrous calcium sulphate in preparation as the particulate reinforcing element of the bio-based composites considered.

2.3 Synthesis of Diitaconate

Dimethyl itaconate was synthesised by esterification of itaconic acid with methanol by the Fischer method which had seen previous success in the literature [65, 14, 15]; this is presented in Figure 1 as a simplified reaction scheme. Method was adapted from the work of Trejbal et al. and involved the mixing of itaconic acid in an excess of methanol in a molar ratio of 1:3 [65]. P-toluenesulphonic acid was used as a heterogeneous strong acid catalyst and made up 4 % w/w of the final reaction mixture. Figure 2 shows how this reaction mixture was placed in the lower round-bottomed flask (Fig.2D), and brought to a vigorous boil at around 130 °C. Vapours of both water and methanol passed up an insulated glass tube (Fig.2E) and were caught in a distillation column (Fig.2G) which was connected to a reboiler (Fig.2F) at it’s base. Temperature at the column’s top (Fig.2H) was retained at around 70 °C by adjusting the temperature of the reboiler (120 °C) and amount

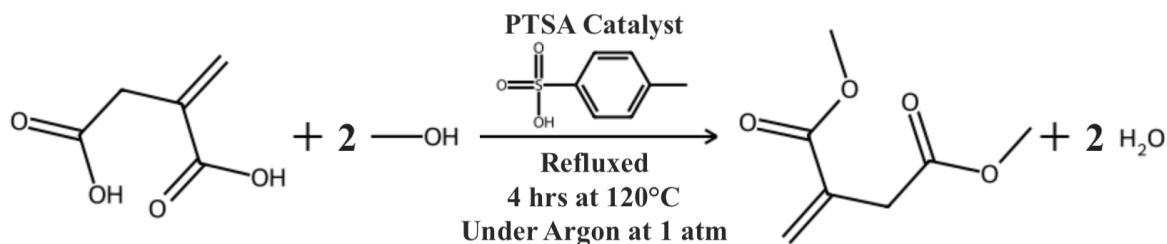


Figure 1: Simple reaction scheme for synthesis of dimethyl itaconate.

of insulation applied around the column; this ensured a steady stream of methanol-rich vapours passing through the Claisen head (Fig.2I) and re-condensing within the Liebig condenser (Fig.2J). Methanol-rich liquid was therewith returned to the lower round-bottomed flask via a dropping funnel (Fig.2K), whilst water was caught in the reboiler (Fig.2F), pushing the reversible esterification reaction toward the desired di-ester product.

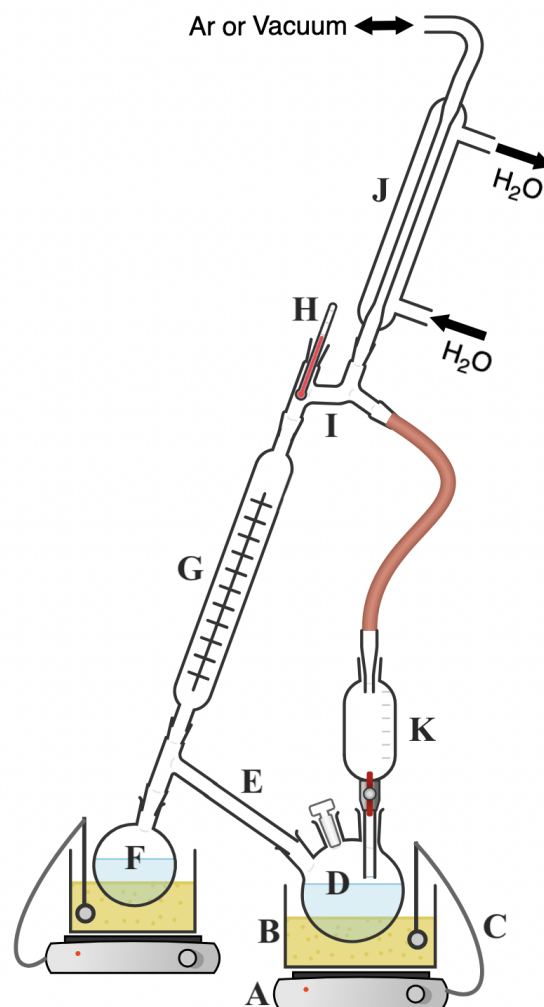


Figure 2: Apparatus for synthesis of dimethyl itaconate [9]. (A) Hotplate stirrer (B) Sand bath (C) Temperature controller probe (D) Three-necked round-bottomed flask containing the reaction mixture (E) Insulated glass tube (F) Single-necked round-bottomed flask acting as a distillation column reboiler containing water (G) Distillation column (H) Thermometer (I) Four-way Claisen head (J) Liebig condenser (K) Dropping funnel for recycled methanol

Before initiating the reaction by starting both the hotplate stirrers (Fig.2A), an argon-rich atmosphere was generated by using a Schlenk line to cycle a vacuum (500 mbar) and argon gas (350 mL min^{-1}); this was to discourage unwanted oxidation reactions and reduce the chances of vapour ignition. During the reaction however a valve was opened to allow pressure equilibration between the reaction vessels and the atmosphere; mitigating the risk of explosion. Methanol cycling was halted 3.5 h into the reaction by closing the dropping funnel's tap (Fig.2K), after which, all heating was ceased on reaching 4 h.

Workup was carried out in toluene; trial-and-error experimentation found this to be suitable for extraction of dimethyl itaconate. Final product mixture retrieved from the

round-bottomed flask (Fig.2D) was placed in a separating funnel with toluene in a 1:3 volume ratio. Separating funnel contents was washed with water thrice, saturated sodium bicarbonate solution twice, and saturated sodium chloride once; each washing step involved a volume ratio of 2:1 between the previously obtained organic fraction and the next volume of washing liquid used. A gravity filtration step was carried out between the water and sodium bicarbonate washing steps to remove insolubles. Following washing, the organic fraction was removed to an Erlenmeyer flask and dried using anhydrous magnesium sulphate; thereafter removed using gravity filtration. Dry organics were placed in a rotary evaporator and heated at 40 °C whilst the pressure was dropped from an initial 70 mbar to 20 mbar over an average period of 8 h; this removed all but a small mass of toluene and water from the liquid product. From this liquid, dimethyl itaconate was crystallised out at room temperature by addition of a nucleating agent. The nucleating agent was crystalline dimethyl itaconate; serendipitously, storage of a particularly pure batch of rotary evaporation product in a fridge at 3 °C lead to the spontaneous nucleation required for freezing- generating the first crystalline sample of dimethyl itaconate. The above method afforded a 45 % yield although higher values may be possible if an extended period of boiling were adopted.

2.4 Diitaconate Characterisation

Characterisation techniques were used to monitor the reaction progress, identify chemicals, and ascertain the product purity; these included thin layer chromatography, Fourier-transform infrared spectroscopy, and nuclear magnetic resonance spectroscopy.

Initial impressions of purity were garnered from spotting chemicals onto thin layer chromatography plates (polyester with a layer of silica gel and ultraviolet indi-

cator; 6 mm pore diameter and 0.2 mm layer thickness) and using a mixture of dichloromethane and methanol (2.5:7.5 v/v respectively) as the mobile phase. On completion, spot(s) could be observed under ultraviolet light (254 nm wavelength) and their retardation factors (R_F) calculated based on equation 1 relating this metric with the distance migrated by the substance in question (b in mm) and that travelled by the mobile phase (a in mm) [20].

$$R_F = \frac{b}{a} \quad (1)$$

Having solvated and diluted pure itaconic acid to a 1.25 % w/w solution (using stock mobile phase), it was spotted on a plate- this produced a single spot with an R_F value of 0.79. Meanwhile, having spotted a 5 % w/w solution of final crystalline product (expected to be dimethyl itaconate) a single spot with an R_F of 0.91 was obtained. These results provided benchmarks by which reaction progress could be gauged as well as supporting the hypothesis that these two crystalline materials were generally quite pure, although we could not rule out the presence of non-fluorescent or trace chemicals using this technique. Samples taken periodically from the reaction vessel (Fig.2D) during the course of an esterification reaction revealed a change in composition: the first sample (retrieved after 15min of heating) presented a single spot with an R_F value of 0.81, whilst a final sample (retrieved after 4 h) presented two spots with R_F values of 0.90 and 0.81 respectively. Given the similarity of these samples with those of the crystalline reactant and product analysed previously, these results indicate the partial conversion of the reactant itaconic acid into the desired product dimethyl itaconate.

Vibrational spectra were obtained using a Nicolet iS50 Fourier-transform infrared spectrometer using the attenuated total reflectance technique; the spectral range between 400-4000 cm^{-1} was investigated at a resolution of 0.09 cm^{-1} . Figure 3 presents

the spectra obtained for the pure reactant (itaconic acid) and compares it with that of the product isolated using the rotary evaporator; this diagram supports the hypothesis that the product was successfully esterified to form the product dimethyl itaconate in a number of ways: Firstly, the broad peak characteristic of O-H bond stretching commonly located between $2500\text{--}3200\text{ cm}^{-1}$ is clearly present for the itaconic acid but not for the product (Fig.3A), suggesting the loss of O-H bonds and therewith the carboxyl groups associated with either the initial reactant (itaconic acid) or the intermediate product (monoethyl itaconate). Secondly, strong peaks are observed around 1710 cm^{-1} (Fig.3B&3D) which is commonly indicative of C=O bond stretching (which occurs between $1640\text{--}1760\text{ cm}^{-1}$); this would be consistent with C=O bond retention which would occur during succesful esterification.

Furthermore, it may be noted that peaks associated with carboxylic C=O bonds occur between $1640\text{--}1730\text{ cm}^{-1}$ whilst ester C=O peaks may occur between $1690\text{--}1750^{-1}$; the positive difference between the reactant C=O peak located at 1700 cm^{-1} (Fig.3B) and the product's peak at 1720 cm^{-1} (Fig.3D) would support succesful esterification. Thirdly, an intermediate-sized peak is observed both for the reactant (Fig.3C) and the product (Fig.3E) at 1630 and 1640 cm^{-1} respectively; their size and location are suggestive of nonconjugated C=C bond stretching (occurring between $1620\text{--}1680\text{ cm}^{-1}$), which would be consistent with retention of the double bond during the proposed esterification. As an aside, clusters of peaks likely associated with C-H bond stretching were observed on both spectra (Fig.3F&3G) but inter-comparison was obfuscated by the strong and broad O-H stretching signal apparent in the reactant's spectrum.

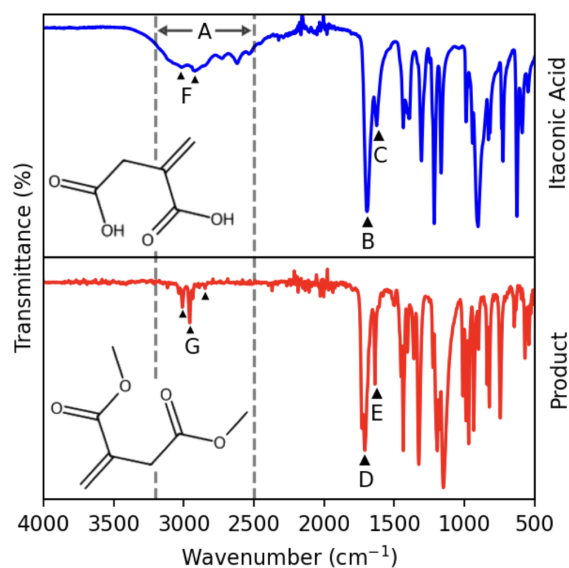


Figure 3: *FT-IR spectra of reactant and product.* (A) $2500\text{--}3200\text{ cm}^{-1}$. (B) 1700 cm^{-1} . (C) 1630 cm^{-1} . (D) 1720 cm^{-1} . (E) 1640 cm^{-1} . (F) 2950 & 3050 cm^{-1} . (G) 2875 , 2980 & 3035 cm^{-1} .

Both ^1H and ^{13}C nuclear magnetic resonance spectroscopy was carried out on a sample of product using a “Bruker Avance III HD 500 MHz Smart Probe” spectrometer, with spectrograms produced at 500 MHz and 125 MHz respectively. Chemical shifts are considered as downfield shifts (δ in ppm) from the tetramethyl silane standard ($\delta = 0$ ppm) and calibrated using the shift exhibited by trace amounts of non-deuterated chloroform ($\delta = 7.26$ ppm singlet for ^1H and $\delta = 77$ ppm triplet for ^{13}C) within the sample solvent. The chloroform-d solvent also introduced a trace amount of water which exhibited a singlet peak ($\delta = 1.63$ ppm) in the ^1H spectrogram; these peaks were ignored when examining the spectra for dimethyl itaconate, as presented here:

Dimethyl itaconate: ^1H NMR (CDCl_3 , 500 MHz): δ 3.34 (d, 2H, $J = 0.71$ Hz), 3.69 (s, 3H), 3.76 (s, 3H), 5.71 (q, 1H, $J = 0.97$ Hz), 6.32 (s, 1H). ^{13}C $\{^1\text{H}\}$ NMR (CDCl_3 , 125 MHz): δ 37.5, 52.1, 52.2, 128.6, 133.7, 166.6, 171.1. [GO BACK OVER THIS WITH THE AID OF "AN OLD CAPTIVITY NOTES FROM 22ND JANUARY 2025"]

A quantitative ^1H spectrogram showed water constituting a 5 % w/w impurity, al-

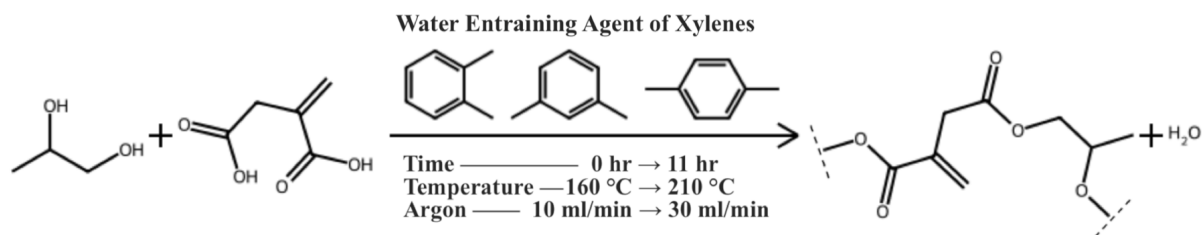


Figure 4: Simple reaction scheme for synthesis of poly(propylene itaconate).

though the dimethyl itaconate sample purity is expected to exceed 95 % given that the deuterated solvent will have introduced an unknown amount of water.

mitigating the removal of water from the bulk mixture and mitigating the combustion risk associated with high temperature xylenes [49].

2.5 Synthesis of Unsaturated Polyester Resin

Unsaturated polyester was synthesised via the polyesterification of itaconic acid with propylene glycol to produce poly(propylene itaconate), as described by the simplified reaction scheme in Figure 4. This was achieved using the melt polycondensation method since a precedent exists in the literature for its successful use in the synthesis of linear unsaturated polyesters derived from itaconic acid [16, 59, 48, 47]. The stoichiometric ratio between itaconic acid and propylene glycol was set at 1:1.1, on the basis that propylene glycol is lost during the heating process which reaches temperatures exceeding its boiling point [49]. Figure 5 shows the apparatus used to synthesise unsaturated polyester; note, a Dean-Stark trap (Fig.5I) has been used allowing the ‘azeotropic method’ of polyester synthesis (as opposed to the ‘dry’ method) which reduces the time taken in synthesising a high molecular weight polyester [49]. In this method, an entraining agent (mixed xylenes) which can form an azeotrope with the water is added to the mixture (5% w/w) [32, 7]; this increases the rate at which water is condensed and trapped by the Dean-Stark, driving the reaction forward by removing the unwanted byproduct of water from the reaction mixture. Furthermore, argon gas was used to sparge the reaction mixture (Fig.5E) facil-

The procedure was initiated by charging the four-necked round-bottomed flask (Fig.5D) with the requisite masses of the two monomers and xylenes, opening the argon taps to provide a 10 mL min⁻¹ flow of sparging gas through the argon injector (Fig.5E) [49], opening the water taps to actively cool the Liebig condenser (Fig.5I), setting the overhead stirrer to a speed of 50 rpm (Fig.5G) [49], and bringing the reaction mixtures temperature (Fig.5F) up to 160 degreeCelsius using the hotplate (Fig.5A). During the procedure the mixture’s temperature was raised monotonically by 10 °C h⁻¹ until it reached a maximum of 210 °C, at which it was held.

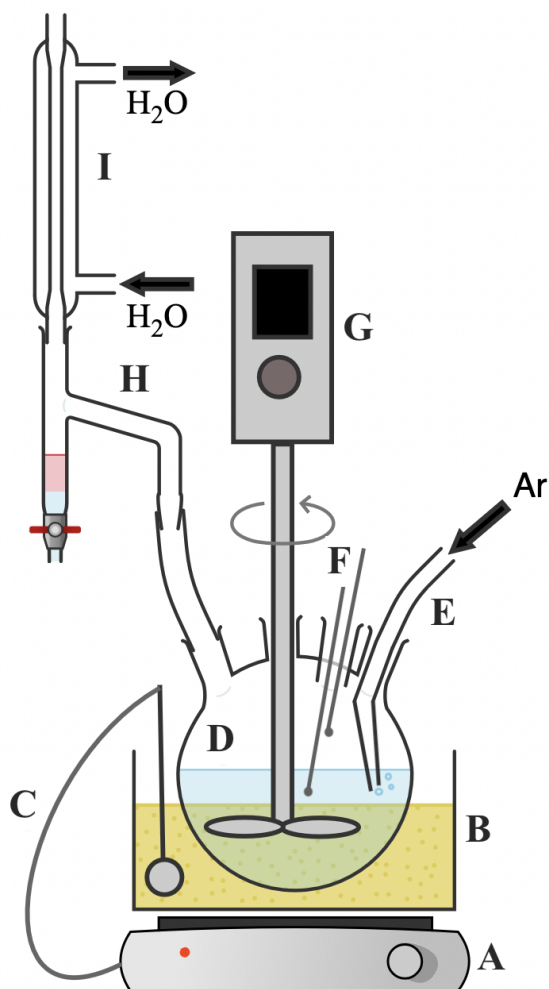


Figure 5: Apparatus for synthesis of unsaturated poly(propyl itaconate) [9]. (A) Hotplate stirrer (B) Sand bath (C) Temperature controller probe (D) Four-necked round-bottomed flask containing the reaction mixture (E) Stainless-steel argon injector (F) Probes for batch and vapour temperatures (G) Overhead stirrer (H) Dean-Stark trap (I) Liebig condenser.

Reaction progress was ascertained by periodically retrieving a sample of the reaction mixture and ascertaining its acid number, whose unit is mg g^{-1} describing the milligrams of potassium hydroxide required to neutralise a gram of sampled unsaturated polyester. This rough form of end-group analysis is commonly used in unsaturated polyester synthesis [48, 59, 13, 49] and provides a proxy value estimating the number of un-esterified acid groups remaining within the unsaturated polyester. An American Society for Testing and Materials standard (“ASTM D4662-20”) was used for this pur-

pose. In-line with common practice, heating of the polyesterifying mixture was ceased at an acid value of 50 [49, 7, 32]. On cessation of heating, an outlet was opened for egress of remnant xylenes and the unsaturated polyester was allowed to cool in an air bath.

Since cooling unsaturated polyester will undergo a monotonic increase in viscosity until it reaches room temperature where it exists as a solid thermoplastic mass; it is therefore common to prepare the unsaturated polyester resin immediately after cessation of heating by adding reactive diluent directly to the cooling unsaturated polyester [49]. Unfortunately, reactive diluents, by their very nature, may be liable to polymerise during this addition causing a premature gelation (untimely and incomplete cross-linking of unsaturated polyester resin usually culminating in the genesis of a rubber-like solid). Mitigation against the dual-threat of hardening into thermoplastic and gelation into rubber is commonly enacted by awaiting a suitable intermediate temperature and addition of an addition-polymerisation inhibiting agent [49, 1, 12]. In this work, we awaited a temperature of 100 ° before adding the requisite masses of inhibitor and reactive diluent. This work adopted the commonly-used free-radical scavenger hydroquinone as an inhibiting agent, and this was added so as to make up 0.06 % w/w of the cooling unsaturated polyester mixture; hydroquinone was dissolved in a small amount of propylene glycol before addition to ensure homogeneity during its mixing into the bulk [49]. The inhibitor percentage was determined through a process of trial-and-error, where lower percentages tended to facilitate premature gelation of unsaturated polyester resins on the shelf, whilst higher percentages caused problems during the curing procedures. Note, the percentage of inhibiting agent was above that which is commonly used in the synthesis of conventional unsaturated polyester resins (approximately 0.02 %) [49, 12]; this was the consequence of both the relatively higher proportion of unsaturated sites along the

polyester backbone and a high copolymerisation affinity between the reactive diluent and the sites of unsaturation. Subsequent introduction and homogenisation of inhibiting agent into the unsaturated polyester mixture, the reactive diluent (dimethyl itaconate) was added such that it made up 30 % w/w of the final unsaturated polyester resin. Reactive diluent content was intentionally less than the commonly used optimal ratios seen in literature, as this was a characteristic that was to be optimised for [49, 1, 12, 7].

2.6 Unsaturated Polyester Resin Characterisation

[WRITE ABOUT GPC OR NMR IF COMPLETED]

2.7 Composite Preparation

Figure 6 presents an overview of the method by which cured thermoset composite samples of various compositions were prepared. Given the danger of self-accelerating decomposition reactions and associated thermal runaway, an external manufacturer was responsible for the mixing and provision of a safely-phlegmatised base initiating agent comprised of dibenzoyl peroxide and calcium sulphate (Fig.6F); this arrived pre-mixed in a set ratio of 2:8 between the dibenzoyl peroxide ($1 - c_2 = 0.2$ w/w) and the calcium sulphate ($c_2 = 0.8$ w/w). Base unsaturated polyester resin was mixed (Fig.6G) in a set ratio of 3:7 between unsaturated polyester resin ($c_1 = 0.7$ w/w) and dimethyl itaconate ($1 - c_1 = 0.3$ w/w) as described previously; the elected ratio represents the lowest amount of reactive diluent possible before viscosity precluded the possibility of further mixing- this increased the size of the possible parameter space to be interrogated (by increasing the range of modified unsaturated polyester resin reactive diluent concentrations that could be mixed to by means of dilution).

Modified unsaturated polyester resin was mixed (Fig.6E) in a varying ratio of $x_1 : (1 - x_1)$ between the base unsaturated polyester resin (x_1 w/w) and the dimethyl itaconate ($1 - x_1$ w/w); by associating the x_1 parameter with a range ([0.45, 1.00]) within which it could vary, we fully describe the first predictor variable to be optimised (x_1 , unsaturated polyester content modifier). Modified initiating agent was mixed (Fig.6D) in a varying ratio of $x_2 : (1 - x_2)$ between the base initiating agent (x_2) and calcium sulphate ($1 - x_2$); x_2 was provided a range ([0.4, 1.00]) hence describing the second predictor variable to be optimised (x_2 , dibenzoyl peroxide content modifier). Initiated unsaturated polyester resin was mixed (Fig.6C) in a varying ratio of $x_3 : (1 - x_3)$ between modified unsaturated polyester resin (x_3) and modified initiating agent ($1 - x_3$); x_3 was provided a range ([0.5, 0.95]) which therewith described the final predictor to be optimised (x_3 , initiating agent content modifier).

Initiated unsaturated polyester resin samples were thermochemically cured into rigid thermoset plastic samples by exposing them to elevated temperatures in a drying oven (Fig.6B); the curing profile was fixed for all samples: 3 hours at 80 °C followed by 1 h at 120 °C. All cured thermoset samples were machined to the same dimensions (Fig.6A) in preparation for characterisation; this was achieved by a grinding process.

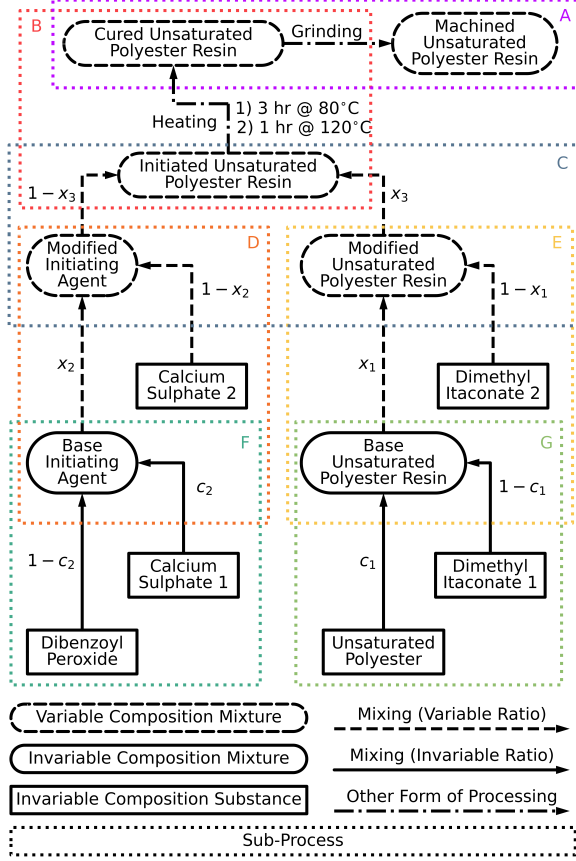


Figure 6: *Mixing and processing schedule for the manufacture of thermoset composite samples. (A) Machining. (B) Thermochemical curing. (C) Mixing for initiated sample. (D) Mixing for modified initiator. (E) Mixing for modified resin. (F) Manufacturer’s mixing for base initiator. (G) In-house mixing for base resin.*

2.8 Composite Characterisation

Given that a key aspect of a thermoset’s utility lies in it’s strength and stiffness within the elastic region of deformation we considered the yield strength and Young’s modulus as legitimate objective variables of interest. Compressive testing was elected as a means by which these metrics could be obtained from samples based on both the simplicity with which a curing regime could be devised for the manufacture of samples of the requisite dimensions and the sparing mass of material required for these. An American Society for Testing and Materials standard was employed (“ASTM D695-23”) in the devising of method; with the cylindrical test sample form, sample diame-

ter of 12.7 mm, and the compression speed of 1.3 mm min^{-1} adopted. However, sample length was adapted down by half (to 12.7 mm) to reduce the mass of material required per sample.

Equipment Compressive testing was carried out using a “Tinius Olsen 50ST” universal test machine (50 kN capacity) fitted with compression platens. Standard software (“Horizon”) purveyed by the machine’s manufacturer was used in the control of the machine, retrieval of data from the load cells, and export of formatted data for further analysis. Exported data consisted of time ($\pm 0.16 \text{ } \mu\text{s}$), force ($\pm 1 \text{ mN}$), and platen displacement ($\pm 1 \text{ nm}$).

Euler Buckling To mitigate against concerns of Euler buckling taking place in samples of the proposed dimensions, we calculated the critical load based on Euler’s critical load equation and some estimated properties for conventional polyester thermosets [21]. Equation 2 shows how the critical load (P_{cr} in N) is related to the elastic modulus of the material (E in Pa), the second moment of area (I in m^4), the effective length factor (K , unitless), and the initial length of the column in question (L in m).

$$P_{cr} = \frac{\pi EI}{(KL)^2} \quad (2)$$

Young’s moduli for conventional thermoset polyesters were expected to range from 2-4.5 GPa [33]. The second moment of the area for the top surface of the cylindrical sample with radius 6.35 mm was calculated to be $1.276 \times 10^{-9} \text{ m}^4$ by assuming it to be a perfect filled circular area, for which the generic equation 3 applied (where the r equated to the radius of the circle in m).

$$I_y = \frac{\pi}{4} r^4 \quad (3)$$

By assuming that both ends of the column would be braced against rotation or translation (given their compression between two platens), the theoretical column effective

length factor would have been 0.5; as a further precaution a conservative design value of 0.65 was assumed based on pertinent literature [60]. On these assumptions it was estimated that the samples in question would be likely to Euler buckle between 433-976 kN. As the compressive strength expected of conventional unsaturated polyester thermosets were to be expected to fall within the range of 89-252 MPa and this corresponded to maximum compressive forces of between 11-32 kN (given the surface area of the samples), we were reassured that the samples were unlikely to experience Euler buckling.

Correction of Raw Data Imperfect rigidity of the test machine itself confounded the raw exported datasets generated for samples tested. By carrying out a compressive test with no sample between the platens, a force-displacement curve representing the inherent stiffness of the machine was generated- this was the correctional dataset. Equation 4 shows how the corrected displacement value (d in mm) could be obtained by taking a raw displacement value (d_{raw} in mm) and subtracting the corresponding correctional displacement value (d_{cor}).

$$d = d_{raw} - d_{cor} \quad (4)$$

Figure 7 presents the correctional dataset, an archetypical raw dataset, and its corresponding corrected dataset. Point ‘A’ is corrected to produce point ‘B’ by using its associated force to find d_{cor} , after which this can be subtracted from its d_{raw} value to produce the d value that point ‘b’ obtains.

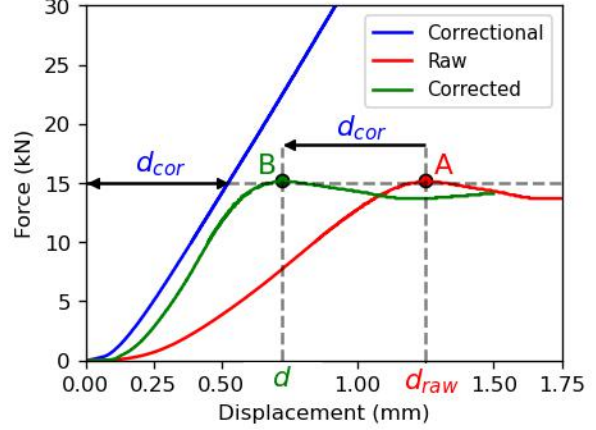


Figure 7: Strain correction of an archetypical raw dataset; the legend notes the various datasets considered.

Processing of Corrected Data Force values from a sample’s corrected dataset were processed into engineering stress values by taking into account the initial surface area. Each cylindrical sample’s diameter was measured using a “Magnusson” digital caliper (accuracy ± 0.02 mm) from three different positions (ϕ_1, ϕ_2, ϕ_3 in mm), each offset by roughly $+45^\circ$ around the circumference, and the mean of these values (ϕ_{avg} in mm) calculated (see Equation 5).

$$\phi_{avg} = \frac{\phi_1 + \phi_2 + \phi_3}{3} \quad (5)$$

Equation 6 shows how the initial top-face surface area was calculated from the average top surface diameter ϕ_{avg} .

$$A_{init} = 0.25 * \pi * \phi_{avg}^2 \quad (6)$$

Subsequently, engineering stress (σ in MPa) could be calculated (Equation 7) by considering the force applied (F in N) and the initial top surface area, A_{init} [41].

$$\sigma_{eng} = \frac{F}{A_{init}} \quad (7)$$

Displacement values from a sample’s corrected dataset were processed into engineering strain values by taking into account the initial length of the samples and the length of the sample during compression. Initial length (l_{init} in mm) was calculated (8) by

taking the mean of three length measurements (l_1, l_2, l_3 in mm) (these taken in the same fashion as for diameter).

$$l_{init} = \frac{l_1 + l_2 + l_3}{3} \quad (8)$$

Equation 9 shows the simple link between length of a sample at a given point during a compressive test (l in mm), the initial sample length (l_{init}) and the corrected displacement at that point d .

$$l = l_{init} - d \quad (9)$$

Subsequently, engineering strain was calculated (10) by finding the absolute change in sample length (Δl_{init} in mm) and dividing this by the initial length of the sample (l_{init}).

$$\epsilon_{eng} = \frac{\Delta l_{init}}{l_{init}} = \frac{l - l_{init}}{l_{init}} \quad (10)$$

Analysis of Stress-Strain Data Figure 8 shows an archetypical example of how stress-strain datasets were used to acquire the Young's modulus and yield strength.

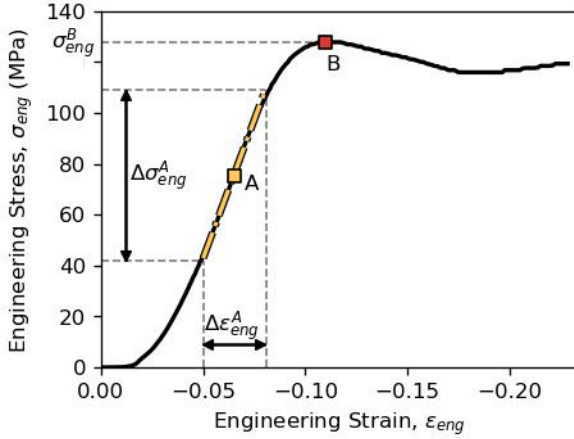


Figure 8: Means by which Young's modulus and yield point were acquired from an archetypical stress-strain dataset. (A) First inflection point. (B) Second inflection point.

A simple algorithm was implemented to locate the first inflection point (Fig.8:A), whereafter a tangent was fitted and the rise (Fig.8: σ_{eng}^A) and run (Fig.8: ϵ_{eng}^A) used to find the gradient. Equation 11 reveals that finding this gradient is analagous to finding the Young's modulus (E in MPa) for the

sample [28].

$$E = \frac{\sigma_{eng}}{\epsilon_{eng}} = \frac{\sigma_{eng}^A}{\epsilon_{eng}^A} \quad (11)$$

Based on it's common definition ("the stress at which a material begins to behave in a plastic fashion"), this work defined (Eq.12) the yield strength (σ_y in MPa) as the stress required to reach the second inflection point (Fig.8:B) [67].

$$\sigma_y = \sigma_{eng}^B \quad (12)$$

2.9 Optimisation

3 Results

4 Conclusion

5 Bibliography

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